



Equipment at a Glance

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 3 of 18 · Foundations · about a 11-minute read

Picture this. Marcus is sitting in Atlanta with an empty trailer, and you find a beautiful load — pays great, perfect timing, goes right where you want him. You book it. You're feeling good. Then you read the details and your stomach drops: the load is **frozen chicken**. It needs a refrigerated trailer. Marcus has a dry van — a plain enclosed box with no cooling. He physically cannot haul this load.

Now you've got a booked load you can't cover, a broker who's about to be very unhappy, and a driver sitting empty while the clock runs.

That mistake takes five seconds to avoid — *if* you can read equipment. The type of trailer a load needs, and how much it weighs, are the very first gate every load has to pass: **can my truck even take this, yes or no?** Get good at that gate and you'll never strand a driver on a load he can't haul.

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Know the main types of trailers and what each one carries, and look at any load and tell — fast — whether your truck can legally and physically haul it. You're not going to become a mechanic. You're going to become someone who never books the wrong load for the truck.

1 Tractor, Trailer — and the Part That Matters

A truck is two pieces: the **tractor** — the front, the engine, the cab where Marcus sits — and the **trailer**, the part that carries the freight. Here's the idea that matters: the tractor can pull almost any trailer, so the thing that actually decides what freight you can haul is the **trailer type**. That's why carriers describe themselves by their trailer — a "dry van carrier," a "reefer carrier," a "flatbed carrier." Summit runs dry vans, so Summit chases dry-van freight. The trailer is your lane into the freight market.

Two quick words for a truck that isn't earning. **Deadhead** you already know — driving with an *empty* trailer, no load, no money, usually to reach your next pickup. Its cousin is **bobtail**: driving the tractor with *no trailer at all* — like when Marcus drops his trailer and drives the bare tractor over to grab a different one. Both burn fuel for zero revenue. When you hear "bobtail" or "deadhead," hear "*the truck is costing money right now, not making it.*"

2 The Big Three Trailer Types

Ninety percent of the freight you'll ever deal with rides on one of three trailers. Learn these cold.

V · VAN

Dry Van

A 53' enclosed box — the workhorse, the most common trailer on the road. General freight: boxes, pallets, packaged goods, paper, electronics, furniture.

R · REEFER

Reefer

A refrigerated van — looks like a dry van, but with a cooling unit and insulated walls. Temperature-sensitive freight: produce, frozen food, meat, dairy, some medicine.

F · FLATBED

Flatbed

An open deck, no walls or roof. Big, heavy, or odd-shaped freight: steel, lumber, pipe, machinery — and the driver must strap and tarp it down.

THE MONEY INSIGHT: A REEFER IS THE MORE FLEXIBLE TRAILER

A reefer can *also* haul regular dry freight — just run it with the cooling off, and it's basically a dry van. But it does **not** work the other way: a dry van can never haul a load that has to stay cold. So a reefer can chase *both* reefer loads and van loads, while a van is limited to dry freight. (Exactly *how* you run the cooling — temperatures, pre-cooling — is saved for the reefer track.)

3 Two More You'll See on the Board

Beyond the big three, two more terms show up often enough that you should recognize them on sight.

SD

Step Deck

A flatbed with a lower deck section — for freight too *tall* to ride legally on a regular flatbed. ("Drop deck" means the same.)

PO

Power-Only

You supply just the tractor (the "power"); the trailer — often pre-loaded — is already there for you to hook and pull.

There are more specialized trailers out there, but they belong to the specialty tracks. The five you now know — van, reefer, flatbed, step deck, power-only — cover the vast majority of what you'll see.

4 Weight & the 80,000-Pound Ceiling

The other half of "can my truck haul this" is weight. Every posting tells you how much the freight weighs, and you need to know what that number means. The key rule: by federal law, a standard truck — tractor, trailer, and cargo together, the **gross weight** — can weigh at most **80,000 pounds** on most highways without special permits.

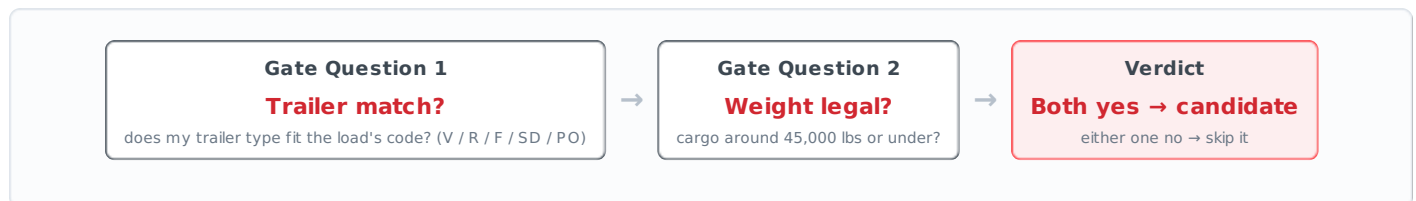
80,000 lb gross limit – ~35,000 lb (empty tractor + trailer) = ~45,000 lb cargo

A standard van or reefer tops out around 45,000 lbs of freight. A posting near that number is a **heavy** load — verify it scales legal before you commit.

A load that puts the truck over 80,000 needs special permits and heavier equipment — that's heavy-haul territory, a specialty topic, not something you book on a standard van. One practical note: different freight "fills up" a trailer differently. Heavy, dense freight like steel can hit the weight limit when the trailer's only half full — it *weighs out*. Light, bulky freight like furniture fills all the space before it nears the weight limit — it *cubes out*. You don't calculate any of this yet; just know "how heavy" and "how much space" are two different limits.

5 The Equipment Gate

Now put it together — this is the actual skill. When a load shows up, *before* you think about rate, you run it through the equipment gate: two quick questions.



Marcus has a dry van, so he can take **V** loads (and a reefer-type load that doesn't need cooling) — but never an **R** load that must stay cold, and never an **F** load that needs an open deck. If both gate answers are yes, it's a real candidate and you keep going. If either is no, you skip it — no matter how good the rate looks — because **a load your truck can't haul isn't a load, it's a trap.**

Walkthrough — Three Postings, One Dry Van

Marcus has an empty dry van in Atlanta. Three loads pop up. Watch the gate in action.

Load A • V • furniture • 38,000 lbs • Atlanta → Dallas

Trailer match? V = van = Marcus ✓ Weight? 38k, well under ~45k ✓ → **CANDIDATE** (this is our anchor load).

Load B • R • frozen chicken • 42,000 lbs • Atlanta → Houston

Trailer match? R = reefer, needs cooling — Marcus's dry van can't keep it cold. X → **SKIP** (doesn't matter what it pays).

Load C • F • steel coils • 47,000 lbs • Atlanta → Memphis

Trailer match? F = flatbed, open deck + securement — not a van. X (Also 47k — heavy.) → **SKIP**.

Three loads, five seconds of judgment, one real option. Marcus takes Load A. Loads B and C might pay beautifully, but they're not for his truck — so you don't waste a second of his day on them. *Gate first, everything else second.*

Module 3 Glossary — your quick reference

The equipment language, in one place.

The Equipment

Tractor	The powered front unit — engine and cab — that pulls a trailer. Pairs with almost any trailer type.
Trailer	The unpowered unit the tractor pulls; the <i>type</i> (van/reefer/flatbed) decides what freight can be hauled.
Dry van (V)	A 53' enclosed trailer for general freight — the most common equipment.
Reefer (R)	A refrigerated, temperature-controlled trailer; can also run as a dry van with the unit off.
Flatbed (F)	An open deck for big or odd-shaped freight; the driver must strap and tarp the load.
Step deck (SD)	A flatbed with a lower deck section, for freight too tall for a standard flatbed.
Power-only (PO)	You supply only the tractor; the trailer (often pre-loaded) is already there to pull.
Bobtail	Driving the tractor with no trailer attached — fuel burned for zero revenue.
Deadhead	Driving with an empty trailer — no load, no revenue, pure cost.
Gross weight	Tractor + trailer + cargo combined; the federal ceiling is 80,000 lbs without permits.

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

1. Name the three main trailer types and one kind of freight each one hauls.
2. Marcus has a dry van. A load of frozen food needs a reefer. Can he take it? Why or why not?
3. A posting shows the cargo weighs 47,000 lbs. What should concern you?
4. Between a dry van and a reefer, which can chase more kinds of loads, and why?
5. What does a "power-only" load mean for your truck?

ANSWERS

1. **Dry van** — enclosed box for general freight (boxes, pallets, furniture). **Reefer** — refrigerated, for temperature-sensitive freight (produce, frozen food). **Flatbed** — open deck for big/odd freight (steel, lumber, machinery).
2. **No.** A dry van has no cooling, so it can't keep the load cold. (And note the reverse: a reefer could haul dry freight, but a van can never haul reefer freight.)
3. That's near or over the practical cargo max (~45,000 lbs) for a standard van once you account for the ~80,000-lb gross limit. It may scale over legal weight — verify before committing; if it truly needs to go heavier, that's permitted heavy-haul, not a standard van load.
4. The **reefer** — it can haul temperature-controlled freight *and* run as a plain dry van with the unit off. A dry van can only haul non-refrigerated freight.
5. You supply only the tractor; the trailer is already provided (often pre-loaded). You just hook to it and pull.

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 4: PHONE FUNDAMENTALS

You can now look at a load and know whether your truck can haul it — the first gate every load has to clear. You've got the world down: the language, the players, the money, and the equipment. Before we go hunting for loads, there's one tool you'll use for absolutely everything ahead — booking, negotiating, problem-solving — and it's the telephone. Next, how to carry yourself on it, because how you sound is part of how you win loads.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson covers equipment across the industry. Your own operation adds its specifics — the actual fleet mix you'll be matching loads against (all dry van? reefers? flatbeds? a blend?), any equipment it specializes in or avoids, and how each carrier's equipment is recorded internally. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*